# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

## Fortune Tellers

A young couple entered the restaurant in Andy's view. They were holding hands. Andy sat back down in his chair. He felt sick. He turned and faced his father, who was eating *xôi*.

"What's the matter, son?" asked his father. "I thought you were going to the birthday party."

"It's too late."

"Are you sure?"

Andy nodded. He looked at the plate of *xôi*. He wanted to bury his face in it.

"Hi, Andy." A voice came from behind.

Andy looked up. He recognized the beautiful face, and he refused to meet her eyes. "Hi, Jennifer," muttered Andy, looking at the floor.

"You didn't miss much, Andy. The party was dead. I was looking for you, hoping you could give me a ride home. Then I met Tim, and he was bored like me. And he said he'd take me home.... Andy, do you want to eat with us? I'll introduce you to Tim."

Andy said, "No, I'm eating *xôi* with my father."

"Well, I'll see you in school then, okay?"

"Yeah." And Andy watched her socks move away from his view.

Andy grabbed a chunk of *xôi*. The rice and beans stuck to his fingernails. He placed the chunk in his mouth and pulled it away from his fingers with his teeth. There was a dry bitter taste. But nothing could be as bitter as he was, so he chewed some more. The bitterness faded as the *xôi* became softer in his mouth, but it was still tasteless. He could hear the young couple talk and giggle. Their words and laughter and the sounds of his own chewing mixed into a sticky mess. The words were bitter and the laughter was tasteless, and once he began to understand this, he tasted the sweetness of *xôi*. Andy enjoyed swallowing the sticky mess down. Andy swallowed everything down—sweetness and bitterness and nothingness and what he thought was love.

Adapted from Nguyen Duc Minh, "Fortune Tellers." in the collection *American Eyes*.

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1. Who is telling this story?

**A.** Jennifer
**B.** Andy
**C.** Tim
**D.** Andy's father
**E.** An unnamed narrator

2. What is the most reasonable conclusion to make from the statement in the first paragraph, "He felt sick."?

**A.** Eating *xoi* with his father gave Andy a stomachache.
**B.** Andy was upset when he saw Jennifer holding hands with Tim.
**C.** Andy was unhappy about the restaurant his father had selected.
**D.** Andy was upset with Jennifer for making him miss the party.
**E.** Andy mistakenly thought that Tim was his best friend.

3. According to the passage, Tim would most likely describe the party as:

**A.** mysterious.
**B.** lively.
**C.** dull.
**D.** upsetting.
**E.** remarkable.

4. Based on the last paragraph, it can be most reasonably inferred that Andy's increasing enjoyment of eating *xôi* was related to:

**A.** hearing Tim and Jennifer laughing and talking.
**B.** the fact that it stuck to his fingernails.
**C.** sitting at a table with Tim and Jennifer while he ate.
**D.** the fact that his father made the *xôi*.
**E.** seeing Tim and Jennifer eating *xôi*.

5. This passage is mainly about the relationship between:

**A.** Andy and his father.
**B.** Andy and Tim.
**C.** Andy's father and Tim.
**D.** Jennifer and Tim.
**E.** Jennifer and Andy.

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

## WRITING A DICTIONARY

When I was about 12, I decided to **(0)** ...A... my own dictionary. I set about my task but almost every strategy I employed proved to be the wrong one for the job **(1)** .......... .

I started with the most obscure words I knew, failing to **(2)** .......... that the meanings of rare words generally have little impact on the overall **(3)** .......... of the text in which they occur. It tends to be common words that pose the problems, their meanings being both **(4)** .......... and unpredictable.

Another mistake that I made was that I arrived at my definitions by looking at those of other dictionaries. I rephrased them of course because even then I was **(5)** .......... aware that I could not simply copy other people's words. But at that time it was not uncommon for lexicographers to **(6)** .......... the work of their predecessors. Nowadays, however, with the **(7)** .......... of large corpora (databases of samples of language), dictionary making has changed beyond all **(8)** .......... .

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **1** | **A** | under review | **B** | for consideration | **C** | in question | **D** | at issue |
| **2** | **A** | regard | **B** | appreciate | **C** | value | **D** | estimate |
| **3** | **A** | assertiveness | **B** | indication | **C** | intelligibility | **D** | conception |
| **4** | **A** | delicate | **B** | slender | **C** | faint | **D** | subtle |
| **5** | **A** | gravely | **B** | severely | **C** | acutely | **D** | vitally |
| **6** | **A** | draw on | **B** | bring off | **C** | pull out | **D** | call up |
| **7** | **A** | approach | **B** | advent | **C** | outbreak | **D** | onset |
| **8** | **A** | consciousness | **B** | awareness | **C** | recognition | **D** | perception |

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

## The Mob Rules

*From schools of fish to a swarm of ants, animals exhibit extraordinary collective behaviour. Iain Couzin explains how they do it.*

With a ripple of light, the fish turn, glide and turn again. Like some animate creature, the school convulses. The predators strike again, two of them coming through the centre of the group, which is briefly ripped apart. Time is suspended as I freeze the image and rotate the group to get a better angle to view the next attack. Now I can pick out the complex vortex of individuals better. At this point, the image suddenly puts me in mind of an experiment I did as a child, holding a magnet over iron filings and watching the effect. With a click of the mouse, life is given back to the virtual creatures, and mesmerising undulations pass across my computer screen once more.

Understanding collective animal behaviour relies on developing computer models of their motion. These help us to explain what has long been a mystery to scientists – how it is possible for fish or birds within a group of thousands of individuals to coordinate their behaviour so closely.

So remarkable is this coherence that, in the 1930s, it was proposed that organisms within such groups must be capable of instantly transferring thoughts to one another. By the 1970s, it was commonly thought that flocking birds required a leader to do this. It was hypothesised that there might be as yet undetected electromagnetic fields generated in the wing muscles or brain of the leader that could be perceived by other group members. It seems plausible – just as an orchestra needs a conductor, so it may seem that a school of fish or flock of birds requires one too. Is this the case, or is there another explanation for such behaviour?

Together with Nigel Franks from the University of Bristol, I have studied the traffic organisation of army ants in the rainforests of Panama. Using computer simulation, we showed that ants use simple rules to organise their traffic. We found that ants spontaneously form a three-lane system: ants returning to the nest with food go along the centre of the trail and those leaving the nest flank either side. Computer simulations, consisting of virtual army ants following these rules, showed us that they have evolved to achieve near optimal performance, permitting the swiftest flow and minimal congestion along trails.

Jostling my way through the overcrowded streets of Oxford, I have often wished we were as unselfish as army ants. The close relatedness of the workers means they have evolved behaviour that benefits the colony. As we are all aware, such altruistic behaviour is not apparent during our walk to work, the push onto a train or the rush for Christmas shopping. On the other hand, we may act more like ants than we think.

Although we have an immensely more complicated brain than ants, much of our behaviour is carried out almost automatically. For instance, when walking down a busy street, humans follow simple and stereotyped movement rules. We balance global, goal-oriented behaviour (a desire to move in a given direction) with local conditions created by the motion of nearby pedestrians. Furthermore, when in a crowd, we have a limited view of our surroundings and often use local information to determine our future movement. Consequently, large-scale patterns are seldom evident from our position, but if you were able to look down upon yourself moving along a busy street, you would notice consistent patterns. Like ants, we too form lanes.

Using computer-modelling methods, Dirk Helbing, a traffic expert at the technical university of Dresden, has investigated human crowds. In the simplest versions, he assumes people tend to slow down and move to avoid local collisions but otherwise walk in their desired direction. Human crowds, however, do not necessarily form three lanes. Each lane tends, instead, to be relatively ephemeral and will be only one, or a few, individuals in width, resulting in a variable number of lanes depending on the environment and the pedestrian density.

The more I study pattern formation, the more I become transfixed by the beauty of nature. When I describe my work to others, they seem to think that studying the patterns and trying to understand them somehow detracts from this. This is far from the case. I wish they could feel the way I do when a flock of pigeons is roused into the air ahead of my footfalls, or when I see an ant in my kitchen struggling with an enormous cake crumb. How dull it would be if fish had leaders, if ants had commanders, or if some entity controlled the motion of animals, like the magnet did the iron filings when I played as a child.

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Why does the writer give the example of the experiment with magnets?

**A** to show how similar forces underlie all natural processes
**B** to emphasise the unpredictable element in nature
**C** to help readers visualise what he is describing
**D** to express his wonder at the scientific world

What is the writer's attitude towards the 1970s explanation for collective animal behaviour?

**A** He considers it to be the result of inadequate scientific research.
**B** He is not certain how it contributes to the broader advance of science.
**C** He doubts whether the most relevant animal groups were studied.
**D** He is not convinced it is the correct way to interpret such behaviour.

The writer refers to the 'push onto a train' (line 25) to illustrate that human communities

**A** are more highly developed than those of ants.
**B** may have similar behaviour patterns to those of ants.
**C** lack some of the co-operative features of the ant colony.
**D** can live in conditions that are as crowded as those of ants.

According to the writer, why are the members of a crowd unaware of any consistent patterns?

**A** They have restricted visibility.
**B** They are often looking downwards.
**C** They fail to analyse what they are doing.
**D** They are focused on reaching their destination.

What has Dirk Helbing's work revealed about human crowds?

**A** People change their direction frequently.
**B** Lanes are only formed for a limited time.
**C** People tend to move at very different speeds.
**D** New lanes are created when they get too wide.

The writer says that, when he describes his work to others,

**A** they seem bored by the details of pattern formation in nature.
**B** they appear confused about what he is trying to achieve.
**C** they are unable to understand the patterns he describes.
**D** they assume he has become less appreciative of nature.

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

**Eudora Welty. From "A Worn Path"**

It was December—a bright frozen day in the early morning. Far out in the country there was an old Negro woman with her head tied in a red rag, coming along a path through the pinewoods. Her name was Phoenix Jackson. She was very old and small and she walked slowly in the dark pine shadows, moving a little from side to side in her steps, with the balanced heaviness and lightness of a pendulum in a grandfather clock. She carried a thin, small cane made from an umbrella, and with this she kept tapping the frozen earth in front of her. This made a grave and persistent noise in the still air that seemed meditative, like the chirping of a solitary little bird.

She wore a dark striped dress reaching down to her shoe tops, and an equally long apron of bleached sugar sacks, with a full pocket: all neat and tidy, but every time she took a step she might have fallen over her shoelaces, which dragged from her unlaced shoes. She looked straight ahead. Her eyes were blue with age. Her skin had a pattern all its own of numberless branching wrinkles and as though a whole little tree stood in the middle of her forehead, but a golden color ran underneath, and the two knobs of her cheeks were illumined by a yellow burning under the dark. Under the red rag her hair came down on her neck in the frailest of ringlets, still black, and with an odor like copper.

Now and then there was a quivering in the thicket. Old Phoenix said, 'Out of my way, all you foxes, owls, beetles, jack rabbits, coons and wild animals! ... Keep out from under these feet, little bob-whites ... Keep the big wild hogs out of my path. Don't let none of those come running my direction. I got a long way.' Under her small black-freckled hand her cane, limber as a buggy whip, would switch at the brush as if to rouse up any hiding things.

On she went. The woods were deep and still. The sun made the pine needles almost too bright to look at, up where the wind rocked. The cones dropped as light as feathers. Down in the hollow was the mourning dove—it was not too late for him.

**Define Each Word**

pendulum:____________________________________________

__________________________________________________

grave:______________________________________________

__________________________________________________

meditative:__________________________________________

__________________________________________________

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frail:_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

limber:_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

**Write the Correct Word from the Vocabulary**

1. Grandmother fell from the steps and broke her hip because her bones were so ________________.
2. After the tragedy, the minister delivered his sermon in ________________, solemn tones.
3. With the disturbing regularity of a ________________, Chris would change his opinion about the principal's performance every week.
4. Marie proved that practicing yoga regularly had made her quite ________________; she could sit on the ground and place both of her legs behind her head.
5. Ervin walked around campus in a thoughtful, ________________ mood, scratching his head and barely noticing where he was going.

**Comprehension and Discussion: Answer Each Question in Complete Sentences**

1. How does the narrator describe Phoenix Jackson's physical appearance?

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

2. In paragraph 3, Phoenix says, "Out of my way, all you foxes, owls…. I got a long way." What does this statement suggest about her personality?

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

_______________________________________________

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

**Guy de Maupassant. From "The Necklace"**

She dressed plainly because she could not dress well, but she was unhappy as if she had really fallen from a higher station; since with women there is neither caste nor rank, for beauty, grace and charm take the place of family and birth. Natural ingenuity, instinct for what is elegant, a supple mind are their sole hierarchy, and often make of women of the people the equals of the very greatest ladies.

Mathilde suffered ceaselessly, feeling herself born to enjoy all delicacies and all luxuries. She was distressed at the poverty of her dwelling, at the bareness of the walls, at the shabby chairs, the ugliness of the curtains. All those things, of which another woman of her rank would never even have been conscious, tortured her and made her angry. The sight of the little Breton peasant who did her humble housework aroused in her despairing regrets and bewildering dreams. She thought of silent antechambers hung with Oriental tapestry, illumined by tall bronze candelabra, and of two great footmen in knee breeches who sleep in the big armchairs, made drowsy by the oppressive heat of the stove. She thought of long reception halls hung with ancient silk, of the dainty cabinets containing priceless curiosities and of the little coquettish perfumed reception rooms made for chatting at five o'clock with intimate friends, with men famous and sought after, whom all women envy and whose attention they all desire.

When she sat down to dinner, before the round table covered with a tablecloth in use three days, opposite her husband, who uncovered the soup tureen and declared with a delighted air, "Ah, the good soup! I don't know anything better than that," she thought of dainty dinners, of shining silverware, of tapestry that peopled the walls with ancient personages and with strange birds flying in the midst of a fairy forest; and she thought of delicious dishes served on marvelous plates and of the whispered gallantries to which you listen with a sphinx-like smile while you are eating the pink meat of a trout or the wings of a quail.

She had no gowns, no jewels, nothing. And she loved nothing but that. She felt made for that. She would have liked so much to please, to be envied, to be charming, and to be sought after.

**Define Each Word**

ingenuity:____________________________________________________________

___________________________________________________________________

supple:______________________________________________________________

___________________________________________________________________

sole:_______________________________________________________________

___________________________________________________________________

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension

oppressive:________________________________________________________________

____________________________________________________________________________

coquette:__________________________________________________________________

____________________________________________________________________________

**Write the Correct Word from the Vocabulary**

1. When her cousin and niece died, Margaret became the ________________ heir to the Brandeis fortune.
2. NASA scientists exhibited exceptional _________________________ when they designed a strong, yet flexible and lightweight spacesuit.
3. During her freshman year, Marie was labeled a ______________________; she considered that label unfair because she believed that she was merely being playful and mildly flirtatious.
4. Josh Hamilton's strong, yet quick and ___________________ wrists help make him a great baseball player.
5. The __________________________ heat of the afternoon sun caused the African violets to wilt.

**Comprehension and Discussion: Answer Each Question in Complete Sentences**

1. Why does Mathilde suffer "ceaselessly"?
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
2. Do you know anyone like Mathilde? If so, describe this person. How do you think this person makes those around him or her feel? Is this person usually happy?
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________
   ____________________________________________________________________________

# 11 Plus Reading Comprehension



## Gas Exchange

**Cross-Curricular Focus: Life Science**

Did you know that your body has its very own gas exchange program that runs 24 hours a day? It's called the **respiratory system**. It is one of your body's vital systems, which means you could not live without it. Every time you take a breath, oxygen enters your lungs and is carried around to all the body's cells by the circulatory system. Waste products, like carbon dioxide gas, are picked up by the circulatory system as well. Carbon dioxide is dropped off at the lungs so you can breathe it out.

The respiratory and circulatory systems need each other. The respiratory system brings in oxygen and pushes out carbon dioxide. The circulatory system transports these gases where they need to go. The two systems work together to make sure that your body gets what it needs to survive. That is why we say that the respiratory and circulatory systems are **interdependent**. They need each other.

The respiratory system is not just your lungs. It also includes your nose, mouth, and the air passageways that connect them to your lungs. After you inhale air through your nose and mouth, it enters a tube in your throat called the trachea. Right before the trachea gets to your lungs, it splits into two smaller tubes called the bronchi. The deeper you go into your lungs, the smaller and smaller the tubes become as they keep dividing in two. The very smallest tubes end with tiny sacs. These sacs look like grape clusters under the microscope. These are called alveoli. They diffuse oxygen into the blood and receive carbon dioxide being returned to the lungs from the blood. Carbon dioxide travels out of your body when you exhale.

Your body has a special way of making sure that you can get the oxygen that you need when you breathe. Your chest actually changes size when you inhale. You have muscles that are attached to your ribs. These muscles pull up when you inhale. Your diaphragm, a large muscle under your lungs, pulls down. This gives plenty of room so you can get the air you need.

Name: ______________________________

**Answer the following questions based on the reading passage. Don't forget to go back to the passage whenever necessary to find or confirm your answers.**

1) What is the purpose of the circulatory system?

________________________________________

________________________________________

2) Identify the parts of the respiratory system.

________________________________________

________________________________________

3) What is the function of the alveoli?

________________________________________

________________________________________

4) How does the body get rid of carbon dioxide?

________________________________________

________________________________________

5) How does your body make room for a deep breath? ______________________________

________________________________________



## It Circulates

**Cross-Curricular Focus: Life Science**

The **circulatory** system is the transport system of the human body. Your body is like a map filled with passageways of different sizes that are filled with blood. **Arteries** and **veins** are the body's largest blood vessels. Arteries carry oxygen-rich blood from the lungs and through the heart so it can be delivered to all the cells of the body. Veins carry carbon dioxide waste back to the heart and into the lungs so the carbon dioxide can be exhaled. **Capillaries** are the tiniest blood vessels. They are especially helpful in the lungs, where the gas exchanges take place in air sacs called alveoli. Under a microscope, alveoli look like grape clusters.

At the very center of the circulatory system is the **heart**. Your heart is about the same size as your fist, but it is made of muscle. Its job is to pump your blood through all those blood vessels. It never stops working, even when you are sleeping. It is the strongest muscle in your body. Your heart has four chambers, or spaces, inside it. They are the left and right **ventricles**, and the left and right atriums. Each chamber is separated by a valve that allows blood flow in only one direction. The opening and closing of the valves is what you can hear through a stethoscope when you visit the doctor. The blood being pushed through the valves is what you feel as your pulse.

Blood looks like a simple red liquid when you have a cut or a scrape. That's only because your eyes cannot see what is going on inside the blood at the microscopic level. The reason blood looks red to us is because it contains an iron-rich substance called hemoglobin. Hemoglobin allows blood to hold on to oxygen and carry it around the body. Hemoglobin is found in disc-shaped cells called red blood cells. There are also white blood cells in our blood. They are larger than red blood cells and are important because they help us fight disease. Platelets, another kind of cell found in our blood, help us form scabs when we are injured so we don't lose too much blood. All of these cells float in a liquid called plasma. Plasma also carries sugar to cells and waste products away from cells.

Name: ______________________________

**Answer the following questions based on the reading passage. Don't forget to go back to the passage whenever necessary to find or confirm your answers.**

1) What is the function of the white blood cells?

________________________________________

________________________________________

2) How are arteries and veins alike?

________________________________________

________________________________________

3) Based on other information in the passage, what gases are being exchanged in the alveoli?

________________________________________

________________________________________

4) What is the main idea of this passage?

________________________________________

________________________________________

5) What does hemoglobin do?

________________________________________

________________________________________